Lesson Plan: Body Paragraphs

This class can be a turning point for many students, as they start to see their essays really take shape. Just having a solid introduction that ends with a strong thesis statement can be a big confidence builder for students, as they start to realize that they're actually writing a great essay. Today's class is all about getting to this point and then pushing them into the rest of their essay!

STUDENTS WILL…

- Review/improve their intros
- Break their thesis statements into parts
- Map out and begin writing their body paragraphs

MATERIALS NEEDED

Slide deck · Student laptops/chromebooks and access to yawp.school

Instructions

1. **Prior to class:** hop on student documents to check their progress on their introductions. Give helpful comments and suggestions. Sometimes students may need a transition sentence that links their intro to their thesis. Feel free to help them with this sort of thing. Reviewing intros prior to class will also let you know if you need to give them more time on intros before launching into Body Paragraphs.
2. Optional: open with the review quiz. Ask the class first, then reveal the answer on the next slide.

   SLIDES 2–11
3. Begin class by asking students to open their YAWP! docs and look at their existing intros/thesis statements.

   a. Refresh their memory about what they did last week (writing intros that prepare the reader to understand their thesis statement). Ask them, "Where does your thesis statement go in your introductory paragraph?" (Answer: the final sentence; feel free to add the disclaimer that this isn't always the case, and it's not a hard and fast rule, but for purposes of this essay, that's where the thesis statement will go.)

      SLIDE 12

   b. Optional: Read the Introduction of the Sample Essay together to provide a shared experience/ understanding of the Introduction.

      SLIDE 21

c. Optional: Spend the first part of class checking in on intro paragraphs with students or having them share with a partner. This kind of review helps students spend time with their essays, which connects them to their writing. As you review each student's intro/thesis, give appropriate praise and feedback to those students who are doing well; ensure that the intro flows nicely into the thesis statement and offer suggestions for linking sentences if this isn't the case. If students have not yet written an intro, give them clear, direct advice and instructions for how they might begin their essays. Avoid writing their intros for them or getting bogged down with one particular student.

The Lesson

1. Using the slide deck, tell the students that once they've dropped their thesis at the end of their introduction, everything they write must in some way define, illustrate, or support their thesis statement. The good news is that their thesis statement tells them exactly where to go from here.

   SLIDES 13–15

2. **Let Your Thesis be your Guide.**

   SLIDES 16–18

   a. Use the example thesis statement to show students how to break their thesis into its parts/elements, noting how these parts become the body paragraphs.

   b. Make sure students are on the **Body Paragraphs** module, and then have them follow the Tutor's instructions for breaking their thesis statements into their parts. Have students review the suggestion to make sure they agree with how it is broken up. They may want to consult with you on this.

   c. It's most effective when students highlight the individual parts of their thesis statement in different colors, as the slides do, like this: *When teacher training programs do not emphasize creative design in lesson plans, teachers fail to understand their role as entertainers, resulting in boring lessons.*

      i. Having this visual will really help students stay organized and focused as they begin their body paragraphs.

      ii. NOTE: Not all thesis statements will have 3 parts: they usually have 2-4 parts (occasionally 5). This is ok! Usually, one part of the thesis will yield one body paragraph, but sometimes a complex idea can yield two (or even three) body paragraphs. Avoid teaching this step like it's required to have a specific amount of body paragraphs, lest students think we're teaching the "5-paragraph essay."

3. Read the **Sample Essay** body paragraphs to reinforce the method and get students in the space of body paragraphs.

   SLIDES 20–23

4. Explain the **House Analogy** to students. Walk them through the four stops on the slide: the neighborhood (the introduction), the front door (the thesis statement), the rooms (the body paragraphs), and back at the door (the conclusion).

   SLIDE 24

5 Writing Activity: Write your Body Paragraphs

SLIDE 25

a. Students should begin writing their first body paragraph that focuses only on the first element of their thesis statement.

b. Use the **“Basic Structure of a Body Paragraph”** slide to help students.

   SLIDE 19

c. Tell students that just as their intro started somewhat generally and got more specific and narrow as it went along, their body paragraphs can also start with the general point/element and then get more specific with examples, analysis, opinions, and conclusions.

d. You should work the room, reading students’ paragraphs, giving feedback and encouragement. As essays take shape, you might start to see a rise in student confidence: celebrate this!

Adapted from Brian Connell’s lesson plan for the YAWP! Writing Program, with slide numbers for the new deck. The house analogy now has its own slide, ahead of the writing activity.